

Guiding Principles of the Neurodiversity-Affirming SLP

Reed Senter, Ph.D. CCC-SLP, BCS-CL

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Disclosures

- Financial:
 - I have no financial disclosures related to this presentation. I receive a salary from DeSales University.
- Non-financial:
 - I have no non-financial disclosures related to this presentation.

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About me!



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Principles of the neurodiversity-affirming SLP

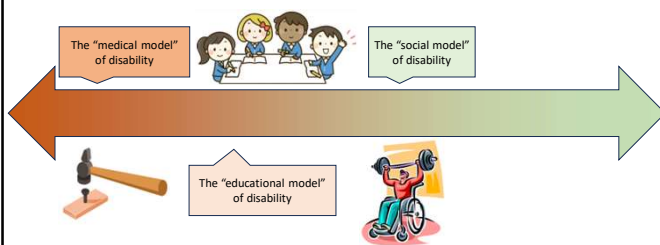
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Principle #1

Know how neurodiversity-affirming services differ from “traditional” models of SLP!

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A continuum of models



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The Social Model of Disability

1. Identify the barriers to access
2. Remove the barriers to access
3. Access!

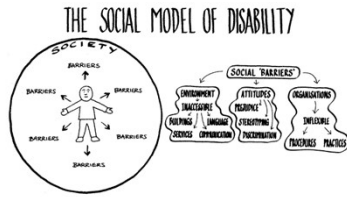


Image source: Democracy Disability and Society Group

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The WHO-ICF Framework

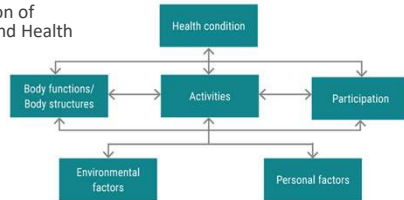
International Classification of
Functioning, Disability, and Health

• ASHA ICF:

<https://www.asha.org/slp/icf/>



Image source: <https://www.icf-casestudies.org>

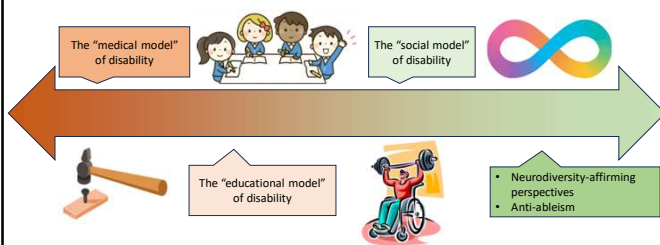


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A continuum of models



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Disability vs. Neurodiversity

- Disability perspectives:
 - There is a "normal" state for humans
 - We celebrate those who exceed normality
 - We consider those who don't meet the "normal" state to be disabled
- Neurodiversity perspectives:
 - "Normal" (or "neurotypical") is a myth
 - Lots of different types of brains; diversity *between* and *within* "neurotypes"
- ND perspectives of disability:
 - Neurodivergence $\neq$ disability
 - Various neurotypes *can be* disabling
 - Million-dollar question: Are those neurotypes inherently disabling, or is the disability a result of social barriers and restrictions?

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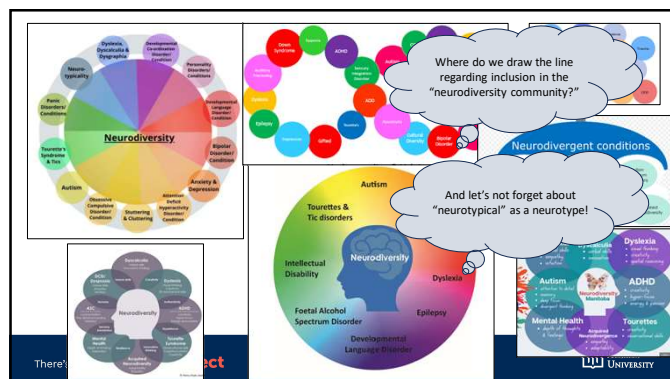


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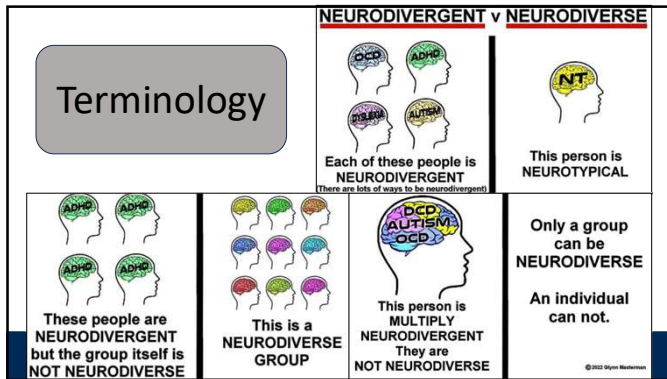
Principle #2

Use the language of the neurodiversity movement!

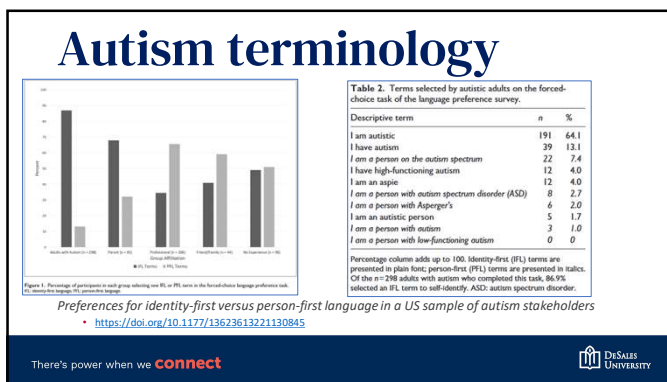
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Autistic terminology

Avoid this!	Use this instead!
Functional labels (High/low functioning, high-low support needs, mild/moderate/severe)	Description of specific strengths and needs
"At risk" for autism	Increased likelihood/chance of autism
Symptoms of autism	Autistic characteristics
Patronizing language (special interests, special needs, superpowers)	Areas of interest (or <i>focused or passionate</i> interest), description of specific needs or strengths
Puzzle pieces	Autism as a part of neurodiversity

• *Avoiding Ableist Language: Suggestions for Autism Researchers*

• <https://www.liebertpub.com/doi/10.1089/aut.2020.0014>

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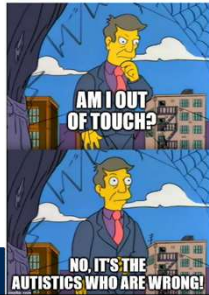
Terminology wars

- "I find that the current battles over terminology, symbols, and approaches to autism are weighing me down."
- "But the endless, conflicting, and often combative social media chatter about autism has me troubled."
- "I have been shaken to the core by a blog—or even by some responses on social media posts—that accuse people of not caring about autistic people because of differences in terminology or approach."

Accepting different opinions about autism

<https://leader.pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/leader.FPLP.28112023.autism-ally-slp.64/full/>

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Principle #3

Promote self-determination
and self-advocacy!

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Self-determination

- Self-determination includes:
 - Control over their own actions and decisions
 - Pursuit of their own goals
 - Access to community
 - Access to services and assistance
- Should be encouraged for *all* clients
 - ...Regardless of disability or severity
 - ...Regardless of intelligence
 - ...Regardless of communication ability

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Self-advocacy

- Built on understanding of oneself
 - What strengths can they draw from?
 - In what area will they require support?
 - Which supports are available and helpful?
 - What rights (incl. legal rights) do they have?
- May benefit from communication services
 - Do they have the means to express self-advocacy? (Spoken language, AAC, etc.)
 - Do they know what they need to say?
 - Can they express it in a way that will be received well? (Pragmatics)

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Principle #4

Remember your 'SLP clichés'!

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“Presume competence”

- Use age-appropriate communication
- Assume that every individual will benefit from learning age-appropriate skills/curriculum, and support access through accommodations and adaptations
- Don't speak *for* the client, and don't have conversations *about* client in front of them as if they aren't there

A strengths-based approach to autism: Neurodiversity and partnering with the autism community

- <https://pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/persp2.SIG1.56>

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“Honor *all* communication”

- No “best-to-worst” rankings of modalities
 - Spoken language = AAC = written language = signed language = _____
 - Our goal is *communication*, not *spoken* communication; AAC is more than a stepping stone or a backup option
- Honor client’s communication preferences
 - Promote multi-modal (or “Total”) communication
 - Preferred modality might vary based on context
- Respect protest and refusal
- Eliminate double-standards
 - Do we ignore neurotypical children’s gestures?
 - Do we insist neurotypical children repeat “I want more” 20x per session?

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Principle #5

Use a person-centered approach in all aspects of practice: Diagnosis, goal-setting, services, etc.

Which brings us to...

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Neurodiversity-affirming services

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Diagnosis

- Remember that “words are powerful”
 - Refer back to recommendations for terminology!
 - Set a positive, warm tone, by identifying parents’ *and* children’s strengths
- Partner with parents during disclosure
 - How are they feeling? What do they already think and know about autism? What supports do they need?
- Consider how interventions are presented
 - Avoid “cure” and “change,” focus on “growth” and “support”
 - Be honest and remain hopeful

Changing the story: How diagnosticians can support a neurodiversity perspective from the start
<https://doi.org/10.1177/13623613211001012>

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Goal-setting

- Functional & meaningful
 - Generalizes to real-life situations
- Improves client's life
 - Happiness, QOL, independence, safety, etc.
- Helps client achieve their own goals
 - Making friends? Attending social events? Dealing with annoyances effectively?
 - Consider collaborative goal-setting...

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Direct services

- Draw from areas of [monotropic] interest
- Emphasize fun
- Be mindful of consent
- Implement strengths-based approaches
 - What skills can the person use effectively?
 - How can we leverage their strengths to support them?



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Indirect services

- Modify the context, not (just) the person
 - Environmental modifications
 - Instructional modifications
- Provide resources and community
 - Emphasize autistic-lead spaces
- Promote understanding & acceptance
 - “Double Empathy Problem”

DOUBLE EMPATHY PROBLEM

Communication between same neurotype

From neurotypical to neurotypical
From autistic to autistic

Efficient

Different neurotype

From neurotypical to autistic
From autistic to neurotypical

Not efficient

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@dat_autistic_advocate

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Trends in ND-affirming services

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Sensory needs

- Consider sensory profiles
 - “4-quadrant model,” considers tolerance and response
 - Sensory profile may vary across senses
 - Credit to Winnie Dunn, an OT
- Sensory needs are dynamic!
 - Across senses
 - Across contexts
 - Within-person variation
- Accommodate sensory needs, and educate communication partners

HIGH TOLERANCE	
Sensory “Missers”	Sensory Seekers
PASSIVE	ACTIVE
Sensory Sensitive	Sensory Avoiders
LOW TOLERANCE	

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Sensory supports

- Common hearing supports:
 - In-ear hearing protection (e.g., Loops)
 - Over-ear hearing protection
- Common visual supports:
 - Hats w/visors, hoods, sunglasses
- Common tactile supports:
 - Weighted blankets and vests, adaptive clothing
- Common movement-based supports:
 - "Heavy work," swinging/bouncing, therabands
- Other common supports:
 - Fidgets & fidget spinners, putty, sensory bins/activities



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The NLA Framework

- "Natural Language Acquisition"
 - AKA, the whole "Gestalt Language Processing" thing
- Premise:
 - Echolalia is a proto-communication, where children learn overextend meaning to entire chunks of language
 - Therapy can focus on systematically "mitigating" these chunks into single units of meaning
- Pros:
 - Validates echolalia as communication
 - Provides systematic guidance for SLPs
- Cons:
 - Relatively weak evidence base (to date)
 - Disagreement about whether echolalia *is* communicative

Further reading:

Using the NLA Protocol to Support Gestalt Language Development
Blanc et al., 2023
https://pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/2023_PERSP-23-00098

"Systematic Review of Interventions Based on Gestalt Language Processing and Natural Language Acquisition"
Bryant et al., 2024
<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10717-024-00332-z>

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Concerns, myths, and misconceptions

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Concern about representation

- Are insights from “high-functioning” autistic adults relevant for children with higher support needs?
- Importance of integrating autistic voices with caregiver input, professional expertise
 - Self-advocacy is important, but not always easy due to communication needs or inflexible expectations
 - Autistic perspectives provide insight and advocacy

Autism and neurodiversity: Addressing concerns and offering implications for the school-based speech-language pathologist.

• https://pubs.asha.org/doi/full/10.1044/2020_PERSP-20-00188

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“Neurodiversity” downplays disability

- Importance of distinguishing autism from associated impairments and conditions
 - Developmental ability: Language, intelligence
 - Medical conditions: Seizures, GI difficulty
 - Psychological disorders: Depression, anxiety
- Importance of recognizing environmental contribution
 - Are autistic traits inherently disabling, or only in the context of social expectations and demands?

Autism and neurodiversity: Addressing concerns and offering implications for the school-based speech-language pathologist.

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“Neurodiversity” eliminates intervention

- Reframe “intervention” as “supports” or “services”
 - Autism can't be “cured,” and doesn't need to be fixed, *but...*
- Autistic people may still need support (and allies)
 - Teaching and practicing skills needed to successfully navigate their world
 - Supporting co-occurring needs and deficits
 - Establishing autistic identity and self-advocacy
- Quote from DeThorne & Sears-Smith's article:
 - “Not wanting to socialize is different from wanting to socialize and being unable to. Both are possibilities for autistic people. One requires acceptance, the other requires assistance. Sadly, I have yet to meet a therapist who doesn't treat the two as equivalent and in equal need of correction.”

Autism and neurodiversity: Addressing concerns and offering implications for the school-based speech-language pathologist.

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Questions?

Contact info:
reed.senter@desales.edu

Find me online:
<https://www.reedsenter.com/>

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